

Post-incident review PIR-2025-014

Customer Portal: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 17 February 2025, Customer Portal experienced stale data shown to users in production (US West) for about 160 minutes. A developer in another team noticed their integration tests failing against the service. Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

Impact

Users of Customer Portal saw stale data shown to users for about 160 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:16 First signal received.
- 09:22 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:44 Likely cause identified.
- 10:08 Mitigation applied.
- 10:44 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

The team first suspected a recent configuration change, but the change log showed nothing relevant.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.
- Exercise the rollback path in staging as part of every release.
- Add a circuit breaker and timeout on the upstream call.